was completed, Akbar released a number of the painters who had been trained and used for this manuscript. This would lead to the first wave of dissemination of the emerging imperial style to new patrons, courts, and connoisseurs, both Hindu and Muslim, across the country. Thus the three painters of the Chunar *Ragamala* were said to have trained under the master Abd al-Samad himself, before leaving for the court of the Rajput prince in Chunar, where they then followed the prince to Rajasthan and served as catalyst for the spread of the Mughal style to Bundi and then Kota.

If the *Hamzanama* with its stories of exciting travels and grandiose battles resonated with Akbar because of his own experiences, there was another manuscript which was also revealing in its implicit message. Early on in his reign Akbar had another story illustrated, the *Tutinama*. This was a fourteenth-century Persian tale within a tale in which a parrot tells a woman whose husband is away a different story each night to prevent the woman from meeting her lover. This work was possibly meant for Akbar's harem which, in addition to the senior Timurid women, now included the Padshah's wives and their many attendants. In this ever-expanding, boisterous company of women, Akbar might have felt the need for some subtle messages on chastity and order.

This early Mughal court of Akbar's had already changed a great deal since the days of Babur and Humayun. There now was a polyphony of voices where earlier Turki had been the beloved mother tongue. The Timurid women, especially Gulbadan, Bega Begum, and Salima Sultan Begum would still be conversant in Turki but now there was a growing influx of Persian-speaking noblemen and scholars and craftsmen, enticed to the court by Akbar to serve as a bulwark against the old, irreducible Turki nobility. There was Brajbhasha, spoken not only by Akbar's Hindu courtiers such as Birbal and Bhagwant Das, but also by his Rajput wives. It was hardly surprising that the young Abdur Rahim, Bairam Khan's son, who grew up in this audacious atmosphere of experimentation and vibrant creativity would go on to become one of the greatest patrons of Persian poetry at the court and would enjoy stories in Turki, Persian, and Hindi while also writing excellent poems in all three languages.

But even as this cauldron of creativity gave rise weekly to masterpieces at court, far away on the southern border of Akbar's empire was a rani who dreamed of lions.